Rahul: You belong to a special school of thought. Do you believe in rebirth?

Me: Noooo!

Rahul: You know, I asked my Dadi once, ‘What would you like to be remembered as after you are gone?’ And Dadi said, ‘I don’t. I will be gone.’ You are from her school of thought … religiously speaking.

Me: I am allowed to use this story, right?

Rahul: That’s up to you. Just keep being human. Mahatma Gandhi travelled across India. Do you know why he did it?

Me: To fight the British and free our country.

Rahul: No, because he wanted to understand India. India is complex—no two parts are the same. The problems of people across India are different. Their aspirations are different. I have to understand it.

Me: So Gandhi walks again in India?

Rahul: Not at all. Don’t even compare. I have no false notions about myself. I am doing this for myself. This is my tapasya. I have to understand the diversity of India.

Me: Understandable …

Rahul: When I understand the different aspects of India from the biggest town to the smallest village, only then will I truly understand the pulse of India. This is my learning.

Me: And in the process get votes?

Rahul: That is not the reason I am walking, but if yes, why not? First thing I have to do is finish my tapasya—and I believe I can do it.

Me: I believe you can do it too. We all do. Thank you, Rahul sir, for the time you gave me and having such an open conversation with me. You are really very nice to talk to.